

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN AFGHANISTAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Afghanistan is the hardest ground in this guide, and honesty begins there: it is one of the most closed and repressive states in the world, independent civil society has been crushed, and no community can safely resist a project on the ground. There is no landmark victory to point to. Across the arid north, the ruling authorities are digging the **Qosh Tepa Canal** to divert the **Amu Darya** — the great shared river of Central Asia — without regional coordination or a water-sharing agreement, drawing down a river the downstream states and the dying Aral Sea depend on. No one disputes Afghanistan's genuine right to its share of that water; the harm resisters name is that it is being taken *unilaterally*, in defiance of the transboundary rules that govern a shared river. Alongside it, the country's copper, lithium, and other minerals are being opened to foreign investors with little scrutiny of their environmental cost.

Those who would resist these harms cannot do so inside the country, but they hold real tools from outside. **International and transboundary water law** — the rules and frameworks governing a shared river — can be invoked, by the downstream states and their allies, to challenge a unilateral diversion and demand coordination. The **international environmental standards** that bind the foreign investors and financiers behind the canal and the mines give resisters a lever to scrutinise and contest the harm. **International bodies, UN agencies, and heritage scrutiny** can be summoned to document and expose it. **Rigorous, open-source documentation** — satellite imagery, hydrological analysis — is the foundation every one of those channels rests on, and one no closed state can suppress, because it needs no one inside. And the **vast Afghan diaspora and international solidarity networks** carry the case and sustain the pressure a silenced domestic public cannot. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The canal is a flagship of the ruling authorities and already far advanced, so no external pressure is likely to halt it. The state is unrecognised and outside the water treaties; the minerals are sought for desperately needed revenue; and there is no landmark victory to promise. Above all, no one inside can be exposed: every step here is external, and the safety of people within the country is the first and overriding rule. So the honest prize is scrutiny, documentation, international accountability, and pressure toward a fairer transboundary settlement — not the stopping of a canal.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot stop a flagship canal or open a closed state, and you must never attempt domestic confrontation, which would endanger the very people you mean to help. What resisters can do is challenge and expose the harm *from outside*: document it rigorously, invoke the international and transboundary rules, scrutinise the foreign partners against their own standards, and carry the case through international bodies and the diaspora — pressing for accountability and a fairer settlement, and protecting anyone inside absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

This is not a fight to halt a project or reform a regime — you can do neither. It is the external, documentary, legal, and advocacy work that contests the harm and presses for accountability, and its realistic prize is scrutiny and pressure, not a stop. Enter it fair to Afghanistan's genuine right to its water, patient with slow and partial gains, and governed at every step by the safety of people inside.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with the ruling authorities, unrecognised by most of the world and outside the regional water treaties; there is no independent court, legislature, or civil society inside to appeal to. The decisions resisters can reach are therefore external — taken in the capitals of the **downstream Central Asian states** (Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan above all), in the **international water and environmental bodies**, among the **foreign financiers and investors** behind the canal and the mines, and in the **UN, climate, and diaspora networks** that can document, fund, and expose.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The canal advances by the authorities' own construction; the minerals move through deals with foreign investors. There is no domestic permit hearing to enter. Resisters enter where the outside world touches the harm: the regional dispute over the shared river, the international standards that bind an investor or financier, the UN and heritage bodies that can scrutinise, and the international press and diaspora that can expose. Each is a point of leverage reached from outside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water first: who downstream loses it, and which international rules govern the sharing. Follow the revenue: which foreign investors and financiers stand behind the minerals, and what environmental standards and reputations they answer to. The permissions that matter are not domestic licences but the standards binding international investors, the obligations of transboundary water law, and the attention of international bodies.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

No domestic watchdog functions. The watchers resisters can summon are external: the downstream governments and regional water bodies, the international water and environmental frameworks, UN and humanitarian agencies, the technical and scientific community that can document diversion and harm, and the international press and diaspora that carry the story.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Afghan effort yields a clean, provable "win," and honesty requires saying so. What the external tools realistically deliver, pressed together, is *scrutiny and pressure*: a unilateral diversion challenged under transboundary water law, a mine contested against international standards, the harm documented and exposed through international bodies and the diaspora. The single most decisive move is **rigorous, open-source documentation of the harm**, because every external lever — the downstream states, the water-law frameworks, the investors' standards, the international bodies — responds to credible evidence, not appeals. Nothing here is fast or certain, and the canal itself is unlikely to be stopped. But the shared river gives the region and the world a genuine legal and moral basis to contest how it is taken.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the unilateral diversion of a shared river, the pressure on the downstream states and the Aral, the unscrutinised mining. **Which rule or standard does it breach?** — transboundary water law, the environmental standards binding a foreign investor, an international body's

mandate. **Who outside shares the interest in contesting it?** — the downstream states, the international community, the technical experts, the diaspora. **Which external channel reaches it?** — a downstream government, a water or environmental framework, an investor's home standards, a UN body. **How is everyone inside kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by keeping all work external and exposing no one. Pick the harm where the breach is clearest and the external channel most concrete.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, all from open, external sources. **Layer one: the harm** — satellite imagery of the canal, hydrological estimates of diversion, the downstream and Aral impacts, the mines' footprint. **Layer two: the breach** — the transboundary rule the unilateral diversion offends, the environmental standard the mining ignores, the coordination the law requires and the authorities skipped. **Layer three: the channel and the protection** — which international water, environmental, or heritage body applies; which downstream government, investor, or framework to reach; and the absolute rule that no person inside is named, exposed, or endangered. A case built on satellite data and hydrology — none of it requiring anyone inside — is one no closed state can suppress.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: satellite imagery (openly available), diversion and flow estimates, downstream-state and Aral-basin data. Gather the **breach record**: the transboundary water rules and instruments the diversion offends, the international environmental standards binding the mineral investors. Gather the **channel record**: the regional water diplomacy already under way among the downstream states, the relevant international bodies, the investors and financiers and the standards they answer to. Gather the **advocacy record**: the diaspora and solidarity networks, the technical and scientific experts, the international press. Above all, gather the **safety discipline**: confirm every source is external and open, and that nothing traces to a person inside.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE REGIONAL, INTERNATIONAL & DIASPORA COALITION

The coalition here is not local — it cannot be — but regional, international, and diaspora-borne, and that is its strength. The **downstream states** have a direct legal stake in the shared river and have already begun regional water diplomacy; they are the most natural partners in contesting a unilateral diversion. The **international water and environmental frameworks** carry the standards a case is argued under. The **technical and scientific community** — hydrologists, basin experts — can document the harm. The **foreign investors' home standards and financiers** are the pressure point on the minerals. And the **vast Afghan diaspora and international solidarity networks** amplify the case and sustain it over years. Build this coalition patiently, from outside, and never in a way that draws in or exposes anyone inside the country.

STEP 4: INTERNATIONAL & LEGAL LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: these levers are real but external, indirect, slow, and partial, and the canal is unlikely to be stopped. What they achieve is challenge, scrutiny, and pressure.

The Transboundary Water-Law Challenge

The **Amu Darya** is a shared river, and its unilateral diversion without coordination or agreement offends the rules of **international and transboundary water law**. Resisters — above all the downstream states and their allies — can invoke those rules to contest the diversion, demand coordination, and press for a negotiated, fair water-sharing arrangement that respects Afghanistan's genuine right while protecting the downstream states and the Aral. The law is the lever; the fair settlement is the aim.

The Minerals Scrutiny

The **copper, lithium, and other minerals** opened to foreign investors can be **scrutinised and contested under the international environmental standards** that bind those investors and their financiers — on water use, contamination, and heritage. The standards, and the investors' need to answer to them, are the tool; exposure and accountability are what they deliver.

The International Pressure and Exposure

Beyond the specific channels, the harm can be carried to the **international bodies, UN and humanitarian agencies, and heritage authorities** whose mandates it touches, and exposed through the **international press and the diaspora**. Pursued together — the water-law challenge, the minerals scrutiny, and the international exposure — these levers contest the harm and press for accountability, from outside, while every person inside is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the downstream states:** this is your water and your Aral, taken without the coordination the law requires; here is the evidence, and here is the legal basis to contest it. **For the international water and environmental frameworks:** here is a transboundary river diverted unilaterally, and here is the standard it breaches. **For the investors and their financiers:** here is a project that fails the environmental standards you are bound by, and here is the record. **For the diaspora and international public:** here is a shared river taken without agreement, and here is the patient, external work that can contest it. **The golden rule:** respect Afghanistan's genuine right, argue the breach and the accountability, never denial — and never in terms that could endanger anyone inside.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters here because the case lives entirely in the external and international arena. Frame the story as a **shared-river-and-accountability** cause: not the denial of Afghanistan's water, but the contesting of a great river taken unilaterally, without the coordination the law and the region require. Carry it through regional and international outlets, the technical and scientific press, and the diaspora networks. A few cautions govern everything: never name or endanger anyone inside; never frame the work as regime confrontation; keep it fair, factual, and grounded in the documented breach; and let the satellite imagery and the hydrology — which require no one inside — carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, fair, and external, and never reference or endanger anyone inside.

8A — To a downstream state or regional water body: state the shared stake in the Amu Darya, attach the diversion evidence, and set out the transboundary-law basis to contest the unilateral diversion and press for a fair, coordinated arrangement.

8B — To an international water or environmental framework: identify the transboundary river diverted without coordination, cite the rule it breaches, and ask for engagement.

8C — To a mineral investor or its financier: present the evidence of environmental harm and ask how the project meets the international standards the investor is bound by.

8D — To an international environmental or heritage body: flag the water, contamination, and heritage risks of the diversion and the mining, and request scrutiny against international standards.

8E — To a UN or humanitarian agency: document the transboundary harm and its downstream and Aral impacts, and ask for the agency's engagement.

8F — To a regional or basin body (the Aral): connect the diversion to the Aral basin's fate and ask for the basin bodies' engagement.

8G — To the diaspora and solidarity networks: share the documented case and ask for amplification, technical help, and sustained external pressure.

8H — To the international community: summarise the shared-river cause, the breach, and the fairness to Afghanistan's right, and ask for support — always without exposing anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: pull the open satellite imagery and the best available hydrology; write the one-page case (the harm, the rule it breaches, the fair settlement sought); identify the single strongest external channel — usually a downstream government or a water framework. **The fastest-moving levers:** the downstream states' existing water diplomacy, the international water-law challenge, and the investors' standards on the minerals. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the diaspora networks and the basin experts first; they mobilise quickly and safely from outside. Throughout, expose no one inside.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by definition: a closed, unrecognised state, a flagship canal, and no domestic recourse. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a stop, but scrutiny, challenge, and pressure toward accountability and a fairer settlement. In a tilted field, lean on the levers the tilt cannot reach: the downstream states' legal interest, the transboundary rules, the investors' binding standards, the international bodies, the diaspora. And accept the honest possibility of losing on any given front — the canal may be built as planned — while still advancing what can move, and defending, always, the people inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt of a determined state from capture — mineral deals that enrich a few, revenue that vanishes. Where capture appears, respond only through the **international channels:** the standards binding foreign investors, the scrutiny of international bodies, the documented record carried by the diaspora and the press. Never pursue it inside, and never in any way that could endanger a person there. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything. Afghanistan is one of the most repressive states in the world;

independent civil society has been crushed; resisting inside is impossible and dangerous. Work only through the regional, international, and diaspora channels; never expose or endanger anyone inside; treat their safety as the first and overriding consideration; and handle the authorities, the recognition question, and the geopolitics only through the documented international record. Protection is not one concern among others — it is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, all from outside. The documented evidence of harm feeds the water-law challenge, the minerals scrutiny, and the international exposure at once; the regional, international, and diaspora coalition organises alongside; the media frames it as a shared-river-and-accountability cause throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the breach from open sources and identify the strongest external channels; **months two to six**, engage the downstream states, the water and environmental frameworks, the investors, and the international bodies, and build the diaspora coalition; **beyond**, sustain the patient external pressure toward accountability and a fairer settlement. The core discipline: fair to Afghanistan's right, patient with partial gains, external in every step, and absolute in protecting anyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Afghanistan is the hardest ground in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the canal can be halted, or that Afghanistan should be denied its water, or that anyone can safely resist inside — none of that is true. What it claims is narrower and real: that a great shared river, diverted unilaterally, gives the downstream states and the world a genuine legal and moral basis to contest how it is taken; that the foreign investors behind the minerals are bound by standards a case can hold them to; and that all of this can be pursued from outside — through transboundary water law, international environmental standards, the international bodies, and the vast diaspora — without ever exposing a single person inside. The levers are external, indirect, slow, and partial, and the prize is scrutiny, accountability, and pressure toward a fairer settlement rather than a clean stop. But for a closed, unrecognised, upstream state on a shared river, that patient, fair, external, protective work is not a lesser ambition — it is the only responsible and effective one.